

Weird is good!

JUST TO BE WEIRD, I decided that you'd need a mirror to be able to read this... or use your phone, take picture, and mirror it... get creative!

If you only knew the people I've hired and worked with over the nearly 16 years that I have been at Digit, you would know that this brand runs on weird. Many of the people who have worked here, including me, are misfits of society who were just too weird to work anywhere else, and while corporate environments might be great for some lines of work, I don't believe it's good for creative work.

You've all read about Google's headquarters, and how they promote a more comfortable working environment and their 20%-time-on-personal-projects idea. They weren't the first and they certainly won't be the last. In fact 3M were doing 15% private projects time decades before Google. In fact, they are well known in this regard, and have other weird policies like never allowing people to work together for too long; instead they shift people to all new teams of people they don't know, just to keep it exciting and new, and also trying out every possible weird combination of teams they can...

The entire startup culture actually thrives on work not feeling like work, but feeling more like you're still in college working on a crazy assignment as a team. This is the stuff we know already. This is the stuff people focus on for things such as productivity, or job satisfaction, but what about creativity?

What we often forget about is that creativity is by its very definition, weird. It can't be creative if it's commonplace can it? It has to be weird, different, a little nuts, shocking, etc. Social media is having a funny effect on us. While it ensures that we focus on other people's weirdness, it somehow also convinces us that we need to fit in. So we have this strange desire to be creative and spontaneous, but at the same time, to not stick out like a sore thumb, which are two goals that are impossible to achieve simultaneously.

Say what you want about the late Steve Jobs, but everyone will agree the man was a genius. Forget Apple, which is what everyone focuses on, and instead look at Pixar. Apple, being a consumer hardware and software company, could never be as creative as Pixar needed to be just in order to survive. So what did Jobs do to encourage creativity? He brought the entire team of Pixar

under one rather large roof, and he made sure he did away with silos, by putting everything that everyone who worked there needed right in the centre of a big hall. The central atrium housed everything that was common, from the cafeteria to the book store, the coffee shops, and yes, even the bathrooms. So people from various departments were forced to interact with one another, to meet one another when doing everyday things like drinking coffee, or even in loos waiting in line to poo when you've drunk too much coffee!

One company has a policy of clicking employee pictures and announcing new hires to their industry... except the pictures are uncensored with full frontal nudity! Too weird? But you're going to Google to try and find out which company it is, aren't you?

Weird just makes sense, and it's the weird that you remember. With 2 billion people online now, weird is in fact the only way for you to be remembered! Which is why this issue decided to focus completely on the weird things in technology, science and culture. It doesn't matter if you work at a job where you think fitting in is best, it's not.

The only way you are ever going to get ahead in life is to embrace what's weird about you, and then let it out slowly. Make sure you don't let it all out at once, or else you're going to be in trouble, because people will just back away slowly and then run away screaming. The key is to recognise when you're subduing a thought, when you're suppressing your weirdness, and then to let just a little of it through.

The next time you're at a station, or in a bus, or in queue, fight your urge to just look at your phone, and try starting up a conversation. If you're already the talkative type, try starting a conversation, but then listening instead of talking. Try some weird responses to simple everyday monotony. Use weird names when placing orders for food, just dial a number randomly and tell them a (clean) joke. Ask them to pass it on to someone they don't know.

The difference between setting up and building a billion dollar company and being a good employee who sits at the same desk until you retire is often just a little weirdness. Embrace your inner weirdness, show it off; and remember to write in and tell me if you do... 



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